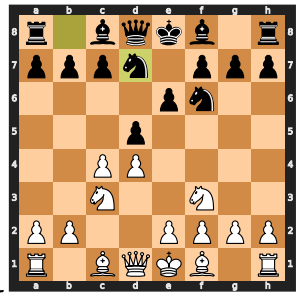
Game 14



Queen's Gambit Declined

Marshall – Capablanca

New York, 1918

White: F. J. Marshall Black: J. R. Capablanca

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

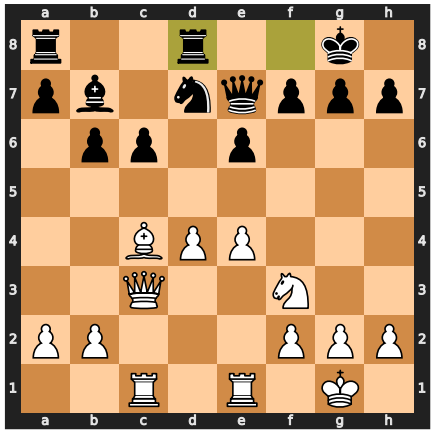
1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.c4 e6 4.♘c3 ♘bd7 5.♗g5 ♗e7 6.e3 0–0 7.♖c1 c6

This is one of the oldest systems of defence against the Queen's Gambit. I had played it before in this Tournament against Kostic, and no doubt Marshall expected it. At times I change my defences, or rather systems of defence; on the other hand, during a Tournament, if one of them has given me good results, I generally play it all the time.

8.♕c2 dxc4 9.♗xc4 ♘d5 10.♗xe7 ♕xe7 11.0–0 ♘xc3 12.♕xc3 b6

This is the key to this system of defence. Having simplified the game considerably by a series of exchanges, Black will now develop his Queen's Bishop along the long diagonal without having created any apparent weakness. The proper development of the Queen's Bishop is Black's greatest problem in the Queen's Gambit.

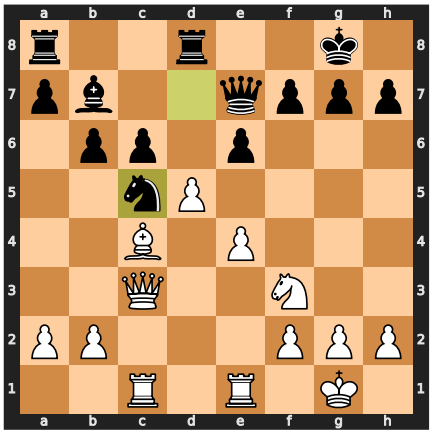
13.e4 ♗b7 14.♖fe1 ♖fd8



The developing stage can now be said to be complete on both sides. The opening is over and the middle-game begins. White, as is generally the case, has obtained the centre. Black, on the other hand, is entrenched in his first three ranks, and if given time will post his Queen's Rook at c8 and his Knight at f6, and finally play ...c5, in order to break up White's centre and give full action to the Black Bishop posted at b7. In this game White attempts to anticipate that plan by initiating an advance on the centre, which, when carefully analysed, is truly an attack against Black's e-pawn.

15.d5 ♘c5!

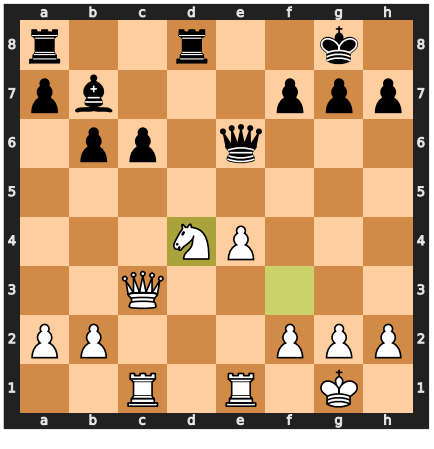
Against Kostic in a previous game I had played 15...♘f8. It was carelessness on my part, but Marshall believed differently, otherwise he would not have played this variation, since, had he analysed this move, he would, I think, have realised that Black would obtain an excellent game. Black now threatens not only ...cxd5; but also ♘xe4; followed by ...cxd5. The position is very interesting and full of possibilities.



16.dxe6 ♘xe6 17.♗xe6 ♕xe6

played under the impression that White had to lose time in defending his a-pawn, when I could play ...c5, obtaining a very superior game. But, as will be seen, my opponent had quite a little surprise for me.

18.♘d4!



18...♕e5!

Of course, if 18...♕xa2 19.♖a1 would win the Queen. The text move is probably the only satisfactory move in the position. The obvious move would have been 18...♕d7 to defend the c-pawn, and then would have come 19.♘f5 f6 20.♕g3 (threatening ♖ad1), 20...♔h8 21.♖cd1 ♕f7 22.h4, with a tremendous advantage in position. The text move, on the other hand, assures Black an even game at the very least, as will soon be seen.

19.♘xc6 ♕xc3 20.♖xc3 ♖d2 21.♖b1

A very serious error of judgment. White is under the impression that he has the better game, because he is a Pawn ahead, but that is not so. The powerful position of the Black Rook at d2 fully compensates Black for the Pawn minus. Besides, the Bishop is better with Rooks than the Knight (see pages 48–56, where the relative values of the Knight and Bishop are compared), and, as already stated, with Pawns on both sides of the board the Bishop is superior because of its long range. Incidentally, this ending will demonstrate the great power of the Bishop. White's best chance was to take a draw at once, thus. 21.♘e7+ ♔f8 22.♖c7 22...♖e8 (not ♗xe4; because f3 would give White the best of it); 23.♖xb7 (best; not ♘g6+, because of ...fxg6; followed by ♖xe4), 23...♖xe7 24.♖b8+ ♖e8 25.♖xe8+ ♔xe8, and with proper play White will draw.

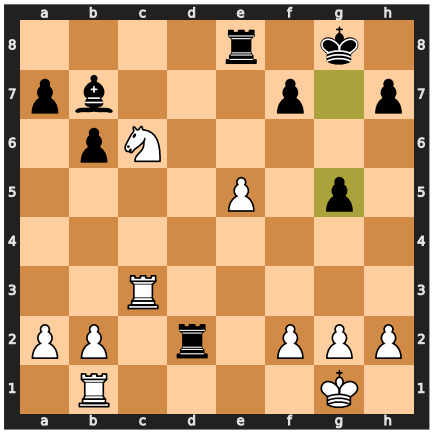
It is curious that, although a Pawn ahead, White is the one who is always in danger. It is only now, after seeing this analysis, that the value of Black's 18th move 18...♕e5 can be fully appreciated.

21...♖e8

With this powerful move Black begins, against White's centre, an assault which will soon be shifted against the King itself. White is afraid to play 22.f3 because of ...f5.

22.e5 g5

To prevent f4. The White Knight is practically pinned, because he does not dare move on account of ♖xe5.



23.h4

This is a sequel to the previous move. White expects to disrupt Black's Pawns, and thus make them weak.

23...gxh4

Though doubled and isolated this Pawn exercises enormous pressure. Black now threatens ♖e6; to be followed by ♖g6 and ...h3 and h2 at the proper time.

24. ♖e1

White cannot stand the slow death any longer. He sees danger everywhere, and wants to avert it by giving up his Queen's side Pawns, expecting to regain his fortunes later on by taking the initiative on the King's side.

24... ♖e6!

Much better than taking Pawns. This forces White to defend the Knight with the Rook at e1, because of the threat ♖g6.

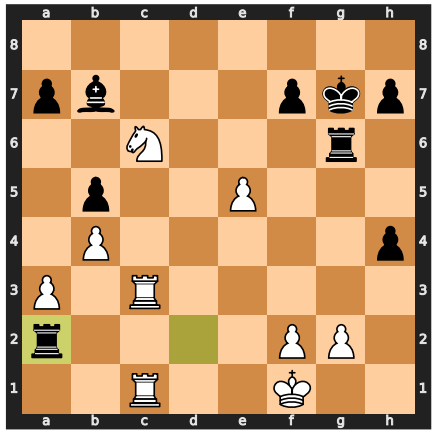
25. ♖ec1 ♔g7

Preparatory to ♖g6. The game is going to be decided on the King's side, and it is the isolated double Pawn that will supply the finishing touch.

26.b4 b5

To prevent b5, defending the Knight and liberating the Rooks.

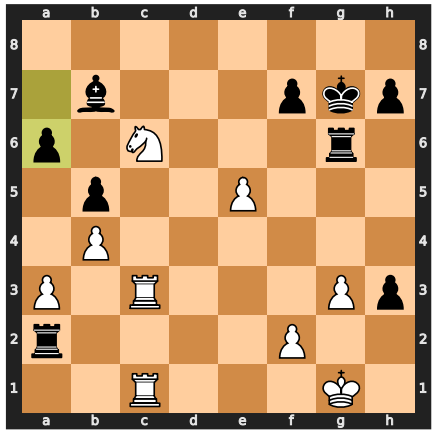
27.a3 ♖g6 28.♔f1 ♖a2



Notice the remarkable position of the pieces. White cannot move anything without incurring some loss. His best chance would have been to play 29.e6, but that would only have prolonged the game, which is lost in any case.

29.♔g1 h3 30.g3 a6

Again forcing White to move and to lose something thereby, as all his pieces are tied up.



31.e6 ♖xe6

Not even now can White move the Knight because of ...h2+; ♔xh2, ♖h6+; ♔g1, ♖h1 mate.

32.g4 ♖h6 33.f3

If 33.g5 h2+ 34.♔h1 ♖xc6 35.♖xc6 ♖xf2, winning easily.

33... ♖d6 34.♘e7 ♖dd2 35.♘f5+ ♔f6

36.♘h4 ♔g5 37.♘f5 ♖g2+ 38.♔f1 h2
39.f4+ ♔xf4
Resigns.

An ending worth very careful study.